



MP3 PLAYERS (PORTABLE)

The Apple iPod is available in 10, 15 and 30 GB storage capacities. We tested the 30 GB model. The 15 GB and 30 GB models ship with a wired remote control, a docking cradle and a carry case. A FireWire cable connects directly to the iPod or to the docking cradle. Alternatively, you may purchase a USB cable. It has five touch sensitive buttons and a scrolling wheel to control the player. The bundled CD comes with iTunes and MusicMatch for both Mac and Windows users.

The 30 GB hard drive stores approximately 7,500 songs, at 4 minutes per song, encoded at in either the MP3 or AAC formats. You can browse by playlist, album, artist, composer, genre or song.

The 'On the Go' feature lets you create a playlist directly on the device. You can also use the device as a portable hard drive to transfer any kind of data between computers. A line-out socket lets you connect the iPod to a stereo system.

You can also play Brick, Parachute

Apple iPod

+ Hard-drive based, FireWire cable bundled, line-out socket, earbud-style earphones

– Very expensive

Price: Rs 45,000 for 30 GB, Rs 36,000 for 15 GB, Rs 28,000 for 10 GB

Contact: Apple Computer International Private Limited

Phone: 080-555 0575

E-mail: indiainfo@asia.apple.com

Reviewed In: September 2003



PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: Creative PA-20

2001: Creative Nomad II MG

and Solitaire, set an alarm that beeps or plays the song of your choice, import your contacts, calendar events, to-do lists, and view text files on the iPod.

The iPod supports the MP3, MP3 Variable Bit Rate, AAC, WAV, AA, and AIFF

WORTHY MENTIONS

Creative Digital MP3 Player LX100

+ Decent set of features, easy installation, large LCD

– No bundled software

Price: Rs 9,799

Contact: Creative Labs Asia

Phone: 98203 57713

E-mail: rajshekhar_bhatt@ctl.creative.com

Reviewed In: September 2003

Ennyah Digisound II DS601 MP3 Player

+ MP3 player cum USB stick, LCD display, cables, strap, 128 MB storage

– Bass output lacking

Price: Rs 6,500 (approx)

Contact: Great World Tech Pvt Ltd

Phone: 022-2389 2828

E-mail: sales@gtechworld.com

Reviewed In: November 2003

audio file formats. The internal lithium-ion battery that generally takes about 3 to 4 hours to charge fully, should last you about 6 hours with lots of scrolling and intermittent use of the backlight.

OPTICAL DRIVES

Ever wondered why so many people are buying CD writers, even though the capacity of an entry-level hard disk is 40 GB? It's because hard disks are not invincible. A surface error on your boot sector is enough to make it practically unusable and give you nightmares. Instead, burn your precious files onto a CD and do away with all the anxiety. With the advent of DVD-ROM drives and the increasing popularity of CD-R/RW drives, it was just a matter of time before combo drives started appearing in the market. They save space, and are an affordable option too.

The packaging and contents of the Sony CRX 300A are very similar to those of its competitors. Apart from the Sony, only Liteon offers a half-height form factor, which is useful for micro-ATX boards and small cabinets. There's a standard single eject button and multi-colour LED on the front bezel. It has a 2 MB buffer that takes care of buffer under-run risks. The Mount Rainier standard is also supported.

Sony CRX 300A

+ Low CD copy time, best performance

– Speed limit feature cannot be turned off

Price: Rs 5,200

Contact: Rashi Peripherals

Phone: 022-2826 0258

E-mail: ho@rpte-chindia.com

Reviewed in:

September 2003



PREVIOUS WINNERS

2002: BenQ DVP-1648A (DVD-ROM), Iomega CDRW55296INT-B (CD Writer)

2001: Aopen 1640 Pro (DVD-ROM)

We used a non-encrypted data DVD-ROM for our Nero DVD Speed tests that yielded results that were quite surprising, to say the least. The burst rate tests yielded extreme highs and lows of data transfer. The CRX won the transfer rate tests, with a speed of 6.2X after a neck-to-neck fight from Liteon. However, its access time scores in the SiSoft Sandra test saw it finishing last.

WORTHY MENTIONS

Liteon LTC48161H

+ Half height, best value

– No data cable bundled, high CD copy time

Price: Rs 3,700

Contact: Mediatech India

Phone: 022-2201 4083

Fax: 022-5639 6696

E-mail: sales@mediatechindia.com

Reviewed in: September 2003

Krypton 52x/32x/52x

+ Low access time, best performance

– No Mt Rainier support, no manual provided

Price: Rs 2,800

Contact: Priya India Ltd

Phone: 022-5666 3100

Fax: 022-5666 3199

E-mail: priyabom@priyagroup.com

Reviewed in: September 2003

Another standard feature of the drive is the ability to copy protected data discs.

Coupled with good build quality, the Sony CRX 300A performed extremely well. If only the speed limit feature could be turned off somehow!